WORLD WAR II

EASTERN SOLOMONS



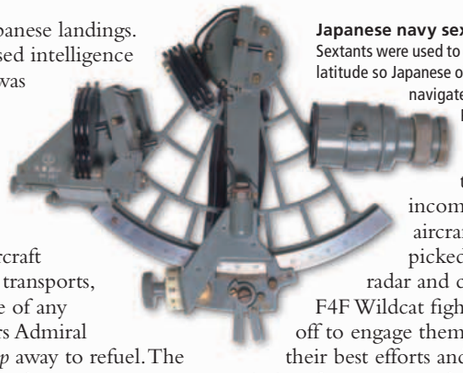
Location Off Solomon Islands

Date August 24,1942
Forces Americans: 2 carriers, 1 battleship, 4 cruisers, 11 destroyers; Japanese: 2 carriers, 1 light carrier, 2 battleships, 16 cruisers, 25 destroyers
Losses Americans: 25 aircraft; Japanese: 1 escort carrier, 75 aircraft

Encouraged by their victory at Savo Island, the Japanese devised Operation Ka, a counteroffensive whose twin objectives were to retake Guadalcanal from the US Marines and to establish naval dominance in the South Pacific by the destruction of American fleet carriers. On August 20, 1942, 3,000 soldiers embarked on transport ships at the Japanese base of Rabaul and headed for Guadalcanal to reinforce a first wave of troops already ashore. Admiral Yamamoto, commander-in-chief of the Japanese Combined Fleet, hoped this troop convoy would lure the American carriers into a trap. His fleet carriers *Shokaku* and *Zuikako*, under Admiral Chuichi Nagumo, would surprise and destroy them, allowing a powerful force of battleships and cruisers to mop up the remaining American ships and support the retaking of Guadalcanal.

In the event, the American carriers *Enterprise*, *Saratoga,* and *Wasp*, under Admiral Frank Fletcher, were already heading toward Guadalcanal in response to the original Japanese landings. Because of confused intelligence reports, Fletcher was unsure whether the Japanese Combined Fleet was in the area. On August 23, an American reconnaissance aircraft spotted the troop transports, but in the absence of any sighting of carriers Admiral Fletcher sent *Wasp* away to refuel. The following morning there were more sightings of Japanese ships, including the light carrier *Ryujo*.

> "BEFORE GUADALCANAL THE ENEMY ADVANCED AT HIS PLEASURE—AFTER GUADALCANAL HE RETREATED AT OURS."
>
> **ADMIRAL WILLIAM HALSEY**, DESCRIBING THE SIGNIFICANCE OF THE CAMPAIGN FOR GUADALCANAL



Japanese navy sextant
Sextants were used to calculate latitude so Japanese officers could navigate around the Pacific Ocean.

BOMBER ATTACKS

In the early afternoon, still unaware of the approaching Japanese fleet carriers, Fletcher ordered a strike by aircraft from *Saratoga* against *Ryujo*, which was duly sunk. Meanwhile, Admiral Nagumo, having located the American carriers, launched waves of torpedo-bombers and dive-bombers to attack them. The incoming Japanese aircraft were picked up on US radar and carrier-based F4F Wildcat fighters flown off to engage them, but despite their best efforts and those of anti-aircraft gunners on the ships, some of the Japanese bombers got through. *Enterprise* received the brunt of the aerial onslaught. Hit by three bombs in rapid succession, the carrier was on fire, listing, and for a time without steering control, yet she survived.

After this the battle petered out, the Japanese battleships and cruisers giving up efforts to locate the US carriers soon after nightfall. The attempt to land einforcements was abandoned the following day.

WORLD WAR II

CAPE ESPERANCE



Location Off Cape Esperance, Guadalcanal

Date October 11-12, 1942
Forces Americans: 4 cruisers, 5 destroyers; Japanese: 3 cruisers, 2 destroyers
Losses Americans: 1 destroyer; Japanese: 1 cruiser, 1 destroyer

Both sides reinforced their troops on Guadalcanal as the ground fighting intensified. On the night of October 11-12 a group of Japanese destroyers was ferrying in soldiers and equipment while another force under Rear Admiral Goto was sent to bombard the airbase at Henderson Field. A US Navy task force of cruisers and destroyers, commanded by Rear Admiral Norman Scott aboard *San Francisco*, had orders to stop Japanese ships entering Ironbottom Sound. Goto's force of three cruisers and a destroyer, detected by radar, was surprised off Savo Island around midnight. Goto's flagship *Aoba* was immediately hit and the admiral fatally wounded. Two other Japanese ships were sunk by gunfire and torpedoes, but the Americans also suffered losses. The light cruiser *Boise*'s magazine exploded killing almost 100 men, and the destroyer *Duncan* was sunk, shelled by both sides in the confusion. Although on balance an American victory, the battle failed to stop the Japanese continuing to land troops.

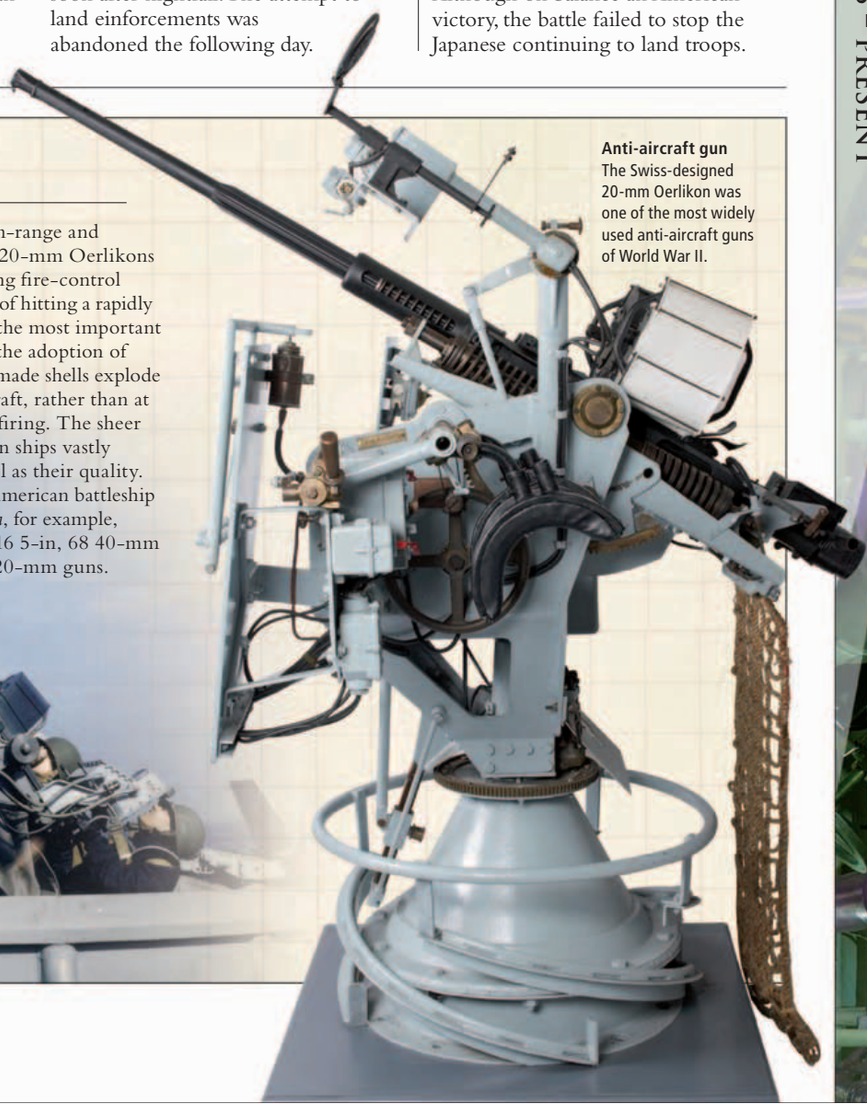
WEAPONS AND TECHNOLOGY

ANTI-AIRCRAFT DEFENSE

American naval defense against air attack improved steadily in the course of the Pacific War. Carrier task forces adopted a circular formation, with carriers in the center surrounded first by a circle of battleships and cruisers and then by an outer ring of destroyers. These ships between them threw up an impressive weight of anti-aircraft fire. The carriers also provided aerial defense, their fighter aircraft guided onto incoming aircraft by radar controllers on the ships. Naval anti-aircraft guns ranged from 5-in guns for long-range fire to 40-mm Bofors for medium-range and .50-caliber machine guns or 20-mm Oerlikons for close-range fire. Improving fire-control systems increased the chances of hitting a rapidly moving target, but probably the most important development in the war was the adoption of radar proximity fuses. These made shells explode when close to an enemy aircraft, rather than at a pre-set time after firing. The sheer number of guns on ships vastly increased as well as their quality. By 1945 the American battleship *South Dakota*, for example, mounted 16 5-in, 68 40-mm and 76 20-mm guns.



Anti-aircraft gun crew
Sailors man an Oerlikon 20-mm anti-aircraft gun during training on board the USS *Iowa* in 1943.



Anti-aircraft gun
The Swiss-designed 20-mm Oerlikon was one of the most widely used anti-aircraft guns of World War II.